

What Is CLOUD GAMING?



(Image courtesy: PlayStation Plus)

What are cloud games? How are they different from online games? What are the pros and cons? And who are the major players in this space? Here are the basics everyone needs to know...

Opportunity knocks

- Gaming brands can tap a greater audience
- Data centres can expand their capacity to host these games
- Internet service providers (ISPs) can sell pro-gaming plans with increased bandwidth and higher speeds
- Television and other device manufacturers can target the gaming community with in-built cloud gaming support
- Makers and sellers of gaming accessories, of course, will have an ever-growing market for their goods!

What are cloud games?

- Cloud games run completely on powerful, remote servers in data centres maintained by large technology companies like Nvidia, Sony, Amazon, Microsoft and Jio.
- No processing happens on the user's computer—they need not download or install anything locally. They can just login and play, like how they stream a movie from an over-the-top (OTT) platform.
- Users' game moves are sent to the server, which processes them, updates the game state, and returns video and audio streams to their computer, in real-time.
- So, users do not need a powerful

computer or large capacity disks—and everyone can play, even the most resource-intensive of games.

- But, to avoid lag, users need a stable and fast Internet connection.
- Cloud gaming service providers offer different levels of subscriptions—basic, premium, etc—and users can access different games based on the plan chosen.
- Many popular online games are also available on cloud gaming platforms now.

What are the advantages of cloud games?

- Users do not need expensive hardware—a simple PC, mobile device, or even a smart TV would do.
- Cloud games are platform-independent, and support most devices and operating systems. Many cloud games also work with virtual reality (VR) headsets.
- Users are freed from responsibilities like downloading, installing, updating software, upgrading hardware, and so on.
- New features get released frequently on cloud games—while they are usually clubbed over a period and released as a new version in online games.
- Piracy is out of the question.

What are the disadvantages of cloud games?

- Users need a stable, lightning-speed Internet connection. Otherwise, there will be a lag between action and reaction. And, a split second often makes the difference between winning and losing a game!
- It also guzzles data—and users might require special packs with high data limits.
- Cloud gaming services have been

rolled out only in some parts of the world. There are only a few players in India, but some global players have announced plans to launch here soon.

- The number of games available on the cloud is much lesser than online gaming now—but this is bound to increase as services get rolled out across the world and adoption increases.

Trends to watch this year

- Cloud gaming service providers and Internet service providers (ISPs) are tying up to offer high-speed connections and cloud gaming subscriptions as a package.
- Customised options are emerging—like bring-your-own-games cloud gaming services that let users install their own games on the cloud; and hybrid solutions that enable users to alternate between online and offline, depending on quality of the connection or data usage.
- Device manufacturers are integrating cloud gaming apps directly into smart TVs and other devices, so users do not have to invest additionally in streaming sticks or consoles.
- Service providers are investing in exclusive games, to differentiate themselves from others. This includes AAA games (high-profile, high-budget games by large and famous production houses)—as these are generally resource-intensive and ideal for cloud gaming.
- Expansion of 5G networks is also a boon for cloud gaming.

Although they sound similar, cloud gaming is quite different from traditional online gaming. More global players are expected to enter the Indian market soon—so get set to board the gravy train! **EFY**

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Cloud gaming services in India

- OnePlay
- JioGamesCloud
- GameAway
- AntCloud

Global players

- Microsoft Xbox Gaming Pass Ultimate
- Nvidia GeForce Now (launching soon in India as well)
- PlayStation Plus
- Amazon Luna
- Boosteroid

ONLINE VS CLOUD GAMING

Online Gaming	Cloud Gaming
Needs to be installed in most cases.	Need not be installed.
Powerful games need powerful computers.	Do not need powerful computers; needs fast internet.
Traditional games are mostly platform-specific. Not all games run on all operating systems.	Mostly platform-agnostic.